

VR Game Design Document

1. Game Overview

1.1 Core Vision

Game Genre:

Single-player, story-driven fantasy RPG.

The player grows from a young apprentice to a master magician, fighting against forces of evil throughout the journey.

Magic System:

Water-based elemental casting. Spells are detailed in the Magic System section.

1.2 Gameplay Style

Genre Style:

First-person, fast-paced spell-casting combat.

Platforms:

As many VR platforms as possible, including:

- Meta Quest
- HTC Vive
- PlayStation VR
- SteamVR
- Other compatible VR platforms

Target Playtime:

- Main storyline: 8–12 hours
- 100% completion: approximately 15 hours

Intended Audience / Rating Target:

ESRB Teen. Potential content includes fantasy violence, blood, and gore (due to Diaphthairo).

The game is intended for players familiar with VR and difficult combat challenges. Combat is meant to be unforgiving.

Art Style:

Realistic animated style, similar to *Jedi: Fallen Order* and *Hogwarts Legacy*.

2. Core Gameplay

2.1 Gameplay Loop

Discover

Find threats in the magical kingdom, secret enemy plans, and other discoveries throughout the world.

Overcome Challenge

Engage in magical combat against rivals or tutors and complete side quests.

Learn

Grow more deft with casting spells and discover powerful combinations. This happens automatically as a result of casting more often.

Upgrade

Add spells to the player's collection by completing lessons with a tutor.

3. Core Design Goals

3.1 Player Experience

The game should feel like a hybrid between a sandbox game and a story-driven RPG. The player should always have plenty of choices and options, even during a fight where every millisecond matters.

The player's real skill should matter more than character stats.

Combat should reward creativity and decision-making over repetition.

Combat should feel like a magical duel, not a shooter.

Positioning matters.

Water availability matters.

Focus management matters.

Spamming a single ability will likely make the player have to respawn in a few seconds.

Most spells should have multiple uses.

Examples:

- Desmá can pull targets, throw them around, or both.
- Rígma can break locks or damage nearby opponents.

Magic should always feel physical.

Every spell must:

- Be recognizable by appearance/silhouette.
- Have its casting gesture described.
- Be usable outside combat where applicable. Most spells should be usable outside combat anywhere where there is water.
- Be understandable without text.
- Reward mastery.
- Never require navigating menus to access or equip the spell.
- Spell recognition is based on the sequence of controller positions, movements, orientations, and required button inputs. Initial gesture states may be shared by multiple spells; subsequent movement and/or button input resolves the intended spell.

3.2 Combat Design

A great duel is fast-paced, high-stakes, and chaotic.

If the player knows everything that is going on every second, it is not fun enough.

If the player knows only half of what is going on, that is better.

If the player does not know anything that just happened in the last second, that is fine, so long as they can recover from the surprise and confusion after a few seconds.

If the player does not know anything that happened during the entire duel, they have probably lost and the game is too unforgiving to be fun.

The environment is part of every fight. Water and casting resources are limited.

3.3 Interface Design

The UI should be ever-present but entirely integrated into the world.

Acceptable UI:

- A blood border around the edges of the player's vision when at low health or after taking damage.
- Text appearing in a spell book at the Library.
- Other text that exists naturally within the game world.
- Subtitles by a person speaking if the user desires or has low volume.

Unacceptable UI:

- Letters or numbers on the screen during combat.
- Text on the screen outside of a location where the text would actually exist.
- Visible health bars over enemies.

Examples of acceptable world-integrated text include text in books or postings over/by doors.

3.4 Input Design

No primary button pressing besides what is already specifically mentioned.

This restriction does not include:

- Triggers
- Grip buttons
- Joysticks

It does include primary/secondary face buttons such as ABXY.

The game should never require opening a combat spell menu.

If the player knows a spell, they can always cast it without switching their loadout.

4. Player Systems

4.1 Health

Health keeps track of how much damage the player has taken.

There is no passive/automatic healing during combat.

Health only regenerates after combat ends.

This intentionally makes the game more difficult while also making it feel more realistic.

4.2 Skill Level

Skill level is a hidden variable counter that tracks how many successful casts the player makes.

Increasing skill increases:

- Maximum Focus
- Focus regeneration
- Water-control capacity
- Minimum Focus required to cast
- Spell efficiency

and decreases:

- Spell cost
- Minimum Focus required to cast

A successful cast is defined as a cast used:

- During combat in a lesson, or
- During a duel with the teacher in a controlled environment.

As the counter increases:

- The player's Focus increases.
- The amount of controllable water increases.

The skill level is not revealed directly to the player.

4.3 Focus

Focus determines how much magic the player can cast and whether the player can successfully cast a spell.

Unlike health, Focus automatically replenishes during combat when the player is not casting.

Maximum Focus and Focus replenishment rate are determined by skill level.

Focus behavior:

- Casting consumes Focus.
- More difficult spells consume more Focus.
- Focus regenerates when the player is not casting.
- Environmental and combat stimulation can slightly reduce Focus regeneration (ie. multiple elements on screen or multiple sounds happening simultaneously). This additional Focus loss is always lesser than the Focus being replenished and is always only a tiny amount. Focus therefore replenishes more slowly during combat as opposed to in a practice room.
- At low Focus, spells may fail.
- At zero Focus, the player cannot successfully cast until Focus recovers.
- As skill level increases, the minimum Focus threshold required for casting diminishes.

Focus is not intended to function as a conventional videogame mana bar.

Focus Feedback

As Focus decreases:

- The player's vision becomes slightly blurred.
- The player's vision becomes desaturated.
- The player's breathing becomes more audibly raspy.
- Spells begin to become unstable or fail entirely.

Focus Values (example):

`focus.spell_cost = spell.difficulty + casting.duration + spell.water_volume - skill_level`

`focus.current = focus.current - focus.spell_cost / 10`

*disclaimer: this is a prototype pseudocode example as to how it might work in application, not a firm “do it this way”. But if we do it this way using OOP we can more easily define attributes for each spell so that something like `katarraktis.water_volume` is 200 while `ydrosphera.water_volume` is 4.

To summarize:

Skill = what the magician is capable of controlling.

Focus = how much magical effort they can currently exert.

5. Movement & Interaction

5.1 General Locomotion

Outside of water, locomotion is always controlled using the joystick and/or head direction.

Walking uses controller joystick movement.

Swimming is available when the player is submerged in water.

5.2 Swimming

The player can choose between two swimming methods in the settings:

Physical Swimming

The player swings their arms in a breaststroke-like motion.

The flipped vector of controller movement determines the vector of movement.

When using physical controller movement to swim, pressing the trigger prevents that controller from affecting the player’s movement. This prevents movement from disrupting spell casting.

Joystick Swimming

Controller joystick movement is combined with the player's head/view direction.

5.3 Spell Dash

The spell dash uses the primary button on the controller.

On Quest, this is the A button.

The non-dominant hand's joystick controls the direction.

The spell uses Focus and is intended for:

- Fast movement
- Dodging during combat

The implementation must be handled carefully because the movement could cause motion sickness.

6. Magic System

6.1 Fundamental Limits of Magic

1. Magicians can only manipulate liquid water within a nearby range. More experienced magicians can control more water.
2. Magicians cannot create water.
3. Magicians cannot directly change the state or temperature of water. They can only change its pressure and density, although changing pressure and density can cause temperature to change slightly.
4. Magic cannot transform water into something else or vice versa.
5. Magicians can only cast one spell at a time.

Ancient Magic breaks some of these rules: it can enable the user to cast two or more spells at once, change flesh into water and water back into flesh (Ydromorfi), and even imbue the water with magic for healing (healing is not intended to be mentioned or used in this game.)

6.2 Magical Progression

In game, magical control is represented through a variable counter that tracks the player's successful casts.

As the player's skill increases:

- Focus increases.
- The amount of water they can control increases.
- The minimum Focus threshold for casting decreases.

Spell progression occurs roughly in order of difficulty.

Exceptions include:

- The player can use Óthisi to push objects and enemies early, but cannot use it for rapid movement until approximately the point at which Ríigma is learned.
- The player learns Asfalís around the same time as Trikymía Lónchis, but Asfalís can be more easily breached upon first learning. Practice makes the shield stronger.
- The player learns Pnigós far later in the game.

Each spell's difficulty also roughly reflects how much Focus it takes to cast.

6.3 Casting Principles

Magic should always feel physical.

Spells do not have individual cooldowns.

Instead, casting uses Focus.

The player does not equip spells to a loadout.

Once the player knows a spell, they can always attempt to cast it without navigating a menu.

The casting gesture itself should communicate what the spell does wherever possible.

A spell gesture consists of a sequence of states. Each state has controller positional/orientation requirements. Transitions occur when the controller enters the next required state. Some states may be shared between multiple spells, but each spell must have a unique series of states. Additional button inputs can

disambiguate otherwise identical gestures. The spell is recognized by the computer only after a complete sequence is satisfied. If the player deviates from the current state, the gesture either fails or may transition into another valid gesture if its requirements are subsequently satisfied.

7. Spell Reference

7.1 Κύμα — Kýma

Translation: Wave

Effect:

Summons and manipulates a wave of water. The size, speed, and force of the wave depend on the amount of water and the magician's control.

Control Type: Instant

Difficulty: ●○○○○○○○○○○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller near the player's side with the palm facing down toward the ground. Press and hold the grip button and trigger. Push the hand forward while simultaneously releasing the grip. Continue holding the trigger.

7.2 Όθηση — Óthisi

Translation: Push

Effect:

Forces an object or person to be shoved in a chosen direction. The strength of the push depends on the magician's Focus and intent.

It can also be used on oneself to quickly move in a desired direction.

Control Type: Instant

Difficulty: ●○○○○○○○○○○○○

Casting Gesture — Pushing Targets:

Same as Kýma, but hold the primary button while casting.

Casting Gesture — Movement Dash:

Press B with the dominant hand and use the non-dominant hand's joystick to choose the direction of horizontal dashing.

Press A for vertical movement and use the joystick for up/down movement.

7.3 Ἑλξη — Élxi

Translation: Pull

Effect:

Pulls an object or person toward the magician.

The speed and force of the pull depend on the magician's Focus and intent. Heavier or resistant targets require more effort.

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●○○○○○○○○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller away from the player with the thumb facing upward, palm facing forward, and fingers facing outward, as if reaching for a mug.

Press and hold the trigger; half-press the grip.

Pull the hand toward the player while simultaneously twisting the wrist so that the palm turns upward and holding the grip.

Continue holding the trigger and grip.

7.4 Υδροσφαίρα — Ydrosphéra

Translation: Water Sphere

Effect:

Conjures an orb of water.

The size and stability of the sphere depend on the amount of water in the environment and the magician's control.

Uses include:

- Containing water
- Transporting water
- Creating a weapon that disperses on impact

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●●●●○○○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller near the player's side with the palm facing upward, as if reaching out for a mug.

Hold the trigger.

After the orb forms:

- Move it around using the hand's position and rotation.
- Grow its size by holding the orb between both hands.
- Throw it by shoving the hand forward and releasing the trigger, as if throwing a ball.
- Crush/end the spell by pressing the grip.

7.5 Νερόφως — Nerófōs

Translation: Water Light

Effect:

Creates a small orb of water similar to Ydrosphéra.

Instead of being a fully formed sphere for transporting water or combat, the orb is compact and emits a soft, continuous glow.

The orb is controlled by the magician. It can:

- Float
- Follow the caster
- Be placed somewhere to provide light

It functions similarly to a lantern.

Brightness depends on the caster's skill and concentration.

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●●●●○○○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller near the player's side with the palm facing upward, as if feeding an apple to a horse.

Hold the trigger and B button.

Crush/end the spell by pressing the grip.

7.6 Πήγμα — Rígma

Translation: Rift

Effect:

Releases a projectile of pressurized water to break or release constraints, such as untying knots or breaking open locks.

It can also damage nearby opponents.

The strength and effectiveness depend on the magician's skill and Focus.

The projectile disperses quickly, making it effective only at close range.

Control Type: Instant

Difficulty: ●●●●●●○○○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller near the opposite side of the body with the forearm in front of the player and the palm facing downward.

Hold the trigger and grip.

Swing the hand outward and forward while releasing the grip.

The motion is similar to pulling a sword from its sheath.

7.7 Τρικυμία Λόγχης — Trikymía Lónchis

Translation: Tempest Spear

Effect:

Conjures one or multiple high-pressure water projectiles and launches them in rapid succession.

The projectiles are capable of piercing opponents.

The number of spears depends on water availability and the magician's skill.

Control Type: Instant

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller near the dominant shoulder with the palm facing inward.

Hold the trigger and grip.

Swing the hand down and forward while releasing the grip.

The motion is similar to throwing a spear or javelin.

7.8 Δίνη Λεπίδων — Díni Lepídon

Translation: Maelstrom Blades

Effect:

Conjures thin, spinning blades of water.

The blades can:

- Orbit the caster.
- Be thrown.
- Cut through enemies.
- Cut through physical defenses.

The strength and number of blades depend on the magician's ability.

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller near the opposite side with the forearm in front of the body and palm facing downward, holding down the grips and triggers.

Mirror this position with the other hand. (At this time the player should have a similar pose to grumpy crossed arms)

Swing both hands forward and outward while twisting the wrists palm-upward and releasing the grip.

After the blades form, they continue to orbit the caster and use up Focus as long as the player maintains holding a trigger.

To end the spell, either:

- Cast another spell, or
- Grab the blades out of orbit and throw them using a motion similar to Ydrosphéra.

7.9 Έκρηξη — Ékriksi

Translation: Explosion

Effect:

Condenses vast amounts of water into as small a space as possible before instantly releasing it outward in a sudden burst.

The resulting explosion can:

- Throw back nearby objects or enemies.
- Damage nearby objects or enemies.
- Clear space.
- Disorient foes.
- Weaken stable structures.

Blast radius and strength depend on player's skill and casting motion.

Control Type: Sustained —> Instant.

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●●○○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold both controllers close to each other in front at waist height with the palms facing each other, pressing the trigger and half-pressing the grip.

Gradually pull both hands upward and apart. A slower, larger (more sustained) pull results in a stronger blast; a quick, tiny pull (less sustained) results in a weaker blast.

Thrust hands back together quickly, releasing the grip and trigger.

7.10 Δεσμά — Desmá

Translation: Shackles

Effect:

Forms long tendrils of water that lash out and grab enemies.

The tendrils can:

- Hold targets in place.
- Drag targets away.

- Throw targets around.
- Slam targets into walls.

Stronger magicians can control multiple tendrils at once to more tightly secure a target or hold multiple targets simultaneously.

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●●○○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller away from the player with the thumb facing outward, palm facing upward, and fingers facing forward, as if presenting a small gift in your palm.

Press and hold the trigger.

Pull the hand toward the player while simultaneously pressing the grip.

Continue holding the trigger and grip.

Move the hand around to move the target.

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7.11 Ασφαλής — Asfalís

Translation: Water Shield

Effect:

Condenses large amounts of surrounding water into a sphere, creating a solid shield of water around the magician.

The barrier absorbs most physical and magical attacks but may weaken or break under sustained or intense force.

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●●○○

Casting Gesture:

Cross both arms and hold both controllers outward and upward, as if cowering in fear.

Press both triggers.

7.12 Καταρράκτης — Katarráktis

Translation: Waterfall

Effect:

Summons a powerful column of water to crash down upon an enemy.

The size and force of the column depend on the magician's strength, Focus, and available water source.

A stronger caster can create a more forceful and concentrated torrent, potentially immobilizing or overwhelming their opponent.

Control Type: Instant

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●●●●○

Casting Gesture:

Hold the controller above the head with the palm facing upward and the fingers facing forward, as if holding up something large with your hand.

Hold the trigger.

Rotate the wrist palm-downward and bring the hand down quickly, as if slamming something onto a table.

8. Dark Magic & Ancient Magic

The following spells are dark magic and are intentionally lower priority for development. Other spells should be implemented first.

⚠️ *Disclaimer: Some of the following spell descriptions are graphic and intense. These descriptions are not intended to explain methods or means to harm a person, but instead to provide clarity as to what the final result should be like in the game. ⚠️

8.1 Πνιγός — Pnigós

Translation: Drowning Grip

Effect:

Constricts water around a target's throat, simulating suffocation regardless of whether the target can normally breathe underwater.

Can be used temporarily as intense torture or prolonged for execution.

Control Type: Sustained

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●○○○

Casting Gesture:

Press the trigger approximately halfway down and make the hand resemble the Darth Vader choking gesture from *Star Wars*. Continue slowly compressing the trigger until the target falls.

8.2 Διαφθείρω — Diaphthairo

Translation: Death

Effect:

Forces the water within a target's body outward at extreme velocity, causing instantaneous fatal trauma.

This spell has similar effects to casting Ékriksi inside the target's body.

Control Type: Instant

Difficulty: ●●●●●●●●●●

Casting:

The player cannot cast this spell.

The Mother invented it, so only she knows how to cast it. Even if the player could learn it, it would be too difficult for them to cast.

Survival:

The only way to survive the spell is to keep the Witch busy so that she never casts it.

8.3 Υδρομορφή — Ydromorfí

Translation: Hydro Morph

Effect: This spell transforms the Mother into a state of pure water. In this form, her body exhibits a mermaid silhouette (as opposed to a human figure) and she can evade physical harm (since she is now liquid water). While morphed, she cannot cast spells.

9. Combat Mechanics & Spell Statistics and Interactions

9.1 Spell Damages

- Κύμα: 2 HP
- Όθισι: 0-15 HP (movement vs. a heavy push that slams the target against a surface)
- Έλξι: 0 HP (draws targets closer rather than inflicting damage)
- Ydrosphéra: 0-5 HP (simply carrying water compared to a heavy swing onto a target)
- Nerófōs: 0 HP (forms light)
- Ρίγμα: 0 HP, 5 HP (breaking locks vs. combat target.)
- Trikymía Lónchis: 15 HP (per spear that hits a target)
- Díni Lepídon: 15 HP (per blade that hits a target)
- Έkriksi: 5-50 HP
- Desmá: 0-25 HP (restraining target vs. a heavy slam against a surface)
- Asfalís: 0 HP (shielding spell)
- Katarráktis: 50 HP
- Pnigós: 5-50 HP
- Diaphthairo: 100 HP

Asfalís: grants +10-35 HP damage immunity to the player. This means that the amount of damage applied to the player is subtracted from the shield's strength.

- Example A: A player casts a shield with 35 HP strength just in time to block a 2-spear Trikymía Lónchis spell. The shield will remain intact, but with only 5 HP damage immunity.
- Example B: A player casts a shield with 35 HP strength in order to block a Katarráktis spell. The shield is breached and -15 HP is dealt to the player (instead of the 50 that would have been dealt had the player not shielded)
- The player has 50 HP; scouts have 25, duelists have 50, sisters have 75, mother has 150 HP.

9.2 Counter Spells [WIP]

- Kýma: Block (Asfalís) or dodge (Óthisi movement)
- Óthisi: Block or dodge
- Élxi: Block or dodge
- Ydrosphéra: Block or dodge
- Nerófōs: N/A
- Rígma: Block or dodge.
- Trikymía Lónchis: Block or dodge
- Díni Lepídon: Block or dodge
- Ékriksi: Block or dodge
- Desmá: Block or dodge; if grabbed, cast a damage spell
- Asfalís: Breach using Katarráktis or Ékriksi.
- Katarráktis: Block or dodge
- Pnigós: Cannot block or dodge; countered using constant damage spells.
- Diaphthairo: Cannot block or dodge; countered using constant damage spells.

**my personal recommendation: while most spells can technically be dodged, some are too fast for dodging to be reliable. When you can, use shields (unless you are confident that you have time to dodge).*

9.3 Succession Combos

- Élxi → Óthisi: Pull an object towards you from afar and throw it at an opponent. Unexpected, easy to cast, and dangerous without expending much Focus. Similar to but more dangerous than Ydrosphéra. (ceramic pots, rocks, etc. work quite well)
- Asfalís → damage spell: Block an opponent's attack and parry with your own. Quite reliable in almost every scenario.

- Élxi → projectile spell (+ Óthisi): pull an opponent closer so that the projectile is easier to aim, then give an optional push so she's even more disoriented.
- Can't think of any more right now.

9.4 Team Combos

- Desmá + damage spell: one member holds an opponent still while the other casts an attack.
- Asfalís + damage spell(s): one member holds a large shield over the team while the others cast attacks.
- Can't think of any more right now.

**Note: Counter-spells and combos shouldn't be hard-coded for the player. Instead, these lists should be used as a reference for how an enemy might behave in combat.*

9.5 Spell Progression

The player learns spells in the following order (subject to change):

- Kýma
- Óthisi
- Élxi
- Ydrosphéra
- Nerófōs
- Ríγμα
- Trikymía Lónchis
- Asfalís
- Desmá
- Ékriksi
- Díni Lepídon
- Katarráktis
- Pnigós

10. World

10.1 Setting

The game takes place in Athea, an underwater city-kingdom, near the end of a generations-long war between two magical groups.

City Size: Approximately 3 miles across.

Population: Approximately 300,000.

The player experiences only a small portion of the city through handcrafted locations. The remainder exists as believable background.

Depth: Approximately 500 feet below the surface.

The surface should be visible when the player looks upward while outside.

Athea has no electricity (much of the light in buildings comes from large skylights in the roofs; candles/lanterns are used where skylights cannot).

Its technology and architecture are roughly comparable to the Roman Empire around 30 AD.

Tallest buildings are approximately four floors tall.

Building interiors are completely dry.

Outdoor areas are submerged.

10.2 Wildlife

Schools of fish, dolphins, whales, crabs, and other aquatic wildlife can be found far above Athea and around it.

Aquatic wildlife is never found inside Athea.

10.3 Historical Context

Not crucial for the game itself, but just cool to know: Long before the setting of the game, humans and mermaids interbred, creating the Aquari. However, the humans were incapable of magic while the mermaids (a species exclusively female) were capable of manipulating water due to their relationship with Thalassa (the sea itself). Thus the Aquari could manipulate water, but only with a fraction of the control of the mermaids. But some of these Aquari descendants

were more mermaid than human, giving them a deeper connection to the sea and therefore Ancient Magic. This ability, centuries later, is what sparked the formation of Thalassa's Adelphía and caused the Mágos Wars.

11. Locations

Palace

The Palace is where the magic happens and serves as the player's home base.

Functions include:

- Learning from tutors.
- Studying in the Library.
- Improving magical ability.

Library

The Library is inside the Palace, a location full of magical books and scrolls.

Functions include:

- Learning from the librarian (Bibliarch).
- Studying on spells (Giving the player actual mechanical hints, lore, new spell applications, counter-spell information, and which spells work best in combos/succession.)
- Improving magical knowledge.

Marketplace

A relatively ordinary part of the city.

Functions include:

- Talking to citizens.
- Exploring.
- General worldbuilding.

Industrial District

Provides opportunities for scouting missions.

Entertainment District

Provides opportunities for scouting missions.

Residential District

Provides opportunities to inquire and talk to citizens.

Outskirts and Aqueducts

Provide opportunities for ambush missions.

Skirmishes

Skirmishes have the possibility of taking place in any location.

12. Magical Law

12.1 The Tidal Code

The Tidal Code establishes the following prohibitions:

1. Performing any forbidden spell or dark magic.
2. Corrupting any crystal, one's own or someone else's, with dark magic, either directly or indirectly.
3. Providing a non-magical Aquari with a magical crystal.
4. Revealing magic to anyone unfamiliar with magic without permission from the Board of Magic.
5. Attempting to train an Aquari in magic without permission from the Board of Magic, including prior to completion of the Board's exams.
6. Providing false witness, incomplete facts, or misleading information to the Board of Magic, including concealing magical knowledge from the Board or concealing the illegal magical actions of any Aquari at any time.
7. Attempting to interfere with a magician's connection to their crystal in any manner.
8. Accessing the Restricted Section of the Palace Library or its contents prior to completion of the Board's exams.

9. Tampering with or destroying magical texts, including taking magical texts outside of the Palace Library without approval from a graduated magician.
 10. Attempting to practice, perform, or study magic without approval from the Board of Magic.
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13. NPCs and Enemies

13.1 NPC Types

Citizen

Non-magical population of Athea.

Primary functions:

- Worldbuilding.
- Social interaction.
- Rumors.
- Occasional side quests.

Citizens cannot directly participate in magical conflicts.

Teacher

Any competent adult magician.

Teachers are experts in magic. The player can seek wisdom from them if they are willing.

Student

The player's fellow peers.

Students provide opportunities to:

- Make friends.
- Get into trouble.
- Occasional side quests

Dark Magician

Dark magicians should not be underestimated.

Classes:

- Scout
- Duelist
- Sister
- Mother

Back-end decision-making pseudocode prototype:

Player casted? → Threat detected? → Can dodge? → Can block? → Reposition
→ Attack

This is a generic loop to check if the player casted towards an enemy NPC, then checks if she can dodge (and if she can't dodge, if she can block), then after blocking, dodging, or being hit, she repositions and attacks.

14. Enemy Classes

14.1 Scout

The most basic magicians in the Adelphía. Scouts can be found in teams of 2-10.

Goal/Priority: Survive and report

Aggression: Low

Coordination: Low

Spell Capability: Basic attacks

Retreat: Easily retreats and easily panics

Speed: Slow; no position rotation

Strengths: None

Weaknesses:

- Little combat experience.
- Low defensive ability.
- Solo combat.
- Poor aim.
- Easily surprised and distracted.
- No shielding ability.
- Vulnerable while investigating disturbances.

Behavior

- Patrol; can be found in most locations.
- Investigate disturbances such as pots breaking or doors opening.
- Prefer survival.
- If half of allies die, have a 60% chance to flee.
- Never initiate difficult spell combos.
- Prioritize dodging over attacking.

14.2 Duelist

The next step up from Scouts. Duelists typically work in teams of 4-8.

Goal/Priority: Surprise and pressure the player

Aggression: Medium

Coordination: Medium

Spell Capability: Most spells; Succession combos

Retreat: Occasionally retreats strategically to regroup later; rarely panics

Speed: Medium; rotates position frequently

Strengths:

- Ambush opening.
- Moderate offensive ability.
- Aim.

Weaknesses:

- Less defensive ability.
- Extra vulnerable during and immediately after casting.
- No shielding ability.

Behavior

- Seek flanking positions.
 - Use stealth-ambush-style to open fights.
 - Use an offense-heavy fighting style with quick movements.
 - Use Óthisi to evade attacks.
 - Can occasionally coordinate two-spell team combos.
-

14.3 Sister

An evil version of a Phylarch partially trained in Ancient Magic. Sisters typically work in teams of 2-3.

Goal/Priority: Control the battlefield and overwhelm the player.

Aggression: High

Coordination: High

Spell Capability: Team combos, low-level dual-casting, low-level dark magic.

Retreat: Never retreats, but can back away; never panics

Speed: Fast; rotates position constantly

Strengths:

- Teamwork.
- Ancient Magic.
- Combat experience.

Weaknesses:

- Shields can be breached with heavy spells such as Ékriksi or Katarráktis.

Behavior

- Use a balanced offense-defense teamwork fighting style.
 - Use Asfalís to block attacks.
 - Heavy attacks can breach shields.
 - Can cast two low-to-mid difficulty spells at once.
 - Coordinate multi-spell team combos.
-

14.4 Mother

The boss. Mother works alone.

The Mother is capable of all of the most powerful magic and Ancient Magic, including Ydromorfí and Diaphthairo. The encounter is designed around survival, observation, timing, and exploiting openings rather than overpowering the opponent.

Goal/Priority: Kill the player

Aggression: Very High

Coordination: Nearly Perfect

Spell Capability: Full set (+ extra)

Retreat: Never

Speed: Very Fast

Strengths:

- Diaphthairo.
- Ydromorfí.

Weaknesses:

- Her normally impenetrable shields become weaker while she is dual-casting (because dual-casting requires her effort to be spread thin). A

sufficiently powerful attack such as Ékriksi or Katarráktis can breach the shield during this brief window. The player must therefore attack her shield while simultaneously avoiding the second spell she is casting.

Behavior:

- Uses a powerful Ancient-Magic solo fighting style.
- Uses Ydromorfí for invulnerability; cannot cast while morphed.
- Can cast two of any spell at once; can cast three spells of equal or lower difficulty to Ydrosphéra at once.

Encounter:

Stage 1: The Mother uses advanced magic but restrains from Ancient magic. During Stage 1 she will never attempt to cast Diaphthairo.

Stage 2: The Mother uses advanced magic and dual-casting.

Stage 3: The Mother uses her full arsenal of spells.

*during stages 2-3, she can occasionally use Ydromorfí to quickly position herself behind you and strike. This causes the player to have to spin around quickly to stay alive.

15. Enemy Combat Rules

Enemy position rotations are defined by where an enemy is relative to their allies and the enemy's combat experience.

A normal magician, including the player, can maintain only one active spell at a time. Ancient Magic allows some enemy magicians to bypass this limitation.

16. Enemy States

Idle

The enemy is standing without actively doing anything; occasional idle dialogue.

Suspicious

Scout-only investigative state.

The Scout cautiously approaches a disturbance (like a pot breaking or a door opening).

Ambush

Duelist-only state. No enemy dialogue. Audio should be extremely quiet or limited when the player enters an ambush strike zone.

The Duelist hides in a location with significant cover and attacks when the player gets close. After attack, the state changes to combat.

Combat

Standard mid-duel state with two sub-states. Scouts and Duelists' dialogue consists of spell incantations; Sisters and the Mother use nonverbal magic (no audible incantations).

- a) Attack: cast an attacking spell
- b) Respond: respond to an attack the player casted, usually blocking or dodging

Disoriented

A brief time in which the opponent cannot cast after being struck by the player's spell. This time gets shorter as the enemy grows in skill (ie. scouts are disoriented the longest; Mother the shortest)

Disadvantaged

A state in which the enemy may:

- Retreat—back away.
- Panic—flee with anxious dialogue.
- Rotate positions.

Defeated

The enemy is dead or unconscious (either based on circumstances/player choice); bodies become rag-doll physics bodies and may float in the water, remain suspended, or sink.

Enemy Victory

The enemy returns to idle-like state but with variations in dialogue; The player becomes unconscious and respawns.

Respawn behavior:

- If accompanied (by teacher or student), return the player to HQ.
 - If alone and on mission, imprison the player with the enemy; the player must then escape to return home.
 - If alone but not on mission, return to HQ.
-

17. Quests and Storyline

17.1 Main Story

Opening — 00:00–00:10

The player starts as a young magician training under the instruction of a Phylarch.

The Phylarch takes the player to the Palace, which serves as the magical HQ, shows the player around, and introduces them to various teachers.

During this time, the player:

- Gets used to on-land locomotion.
- Gets used to in-water locomotion.
- Has opportunity to configure settings.
- Begins their journey in the Mágos Wars.

Early Training — 00:10–00:30

The player meets their colleagues.

Their teacher teaches them in introductory magic.

The player learns the basic spells:

- Kýma

- Óthisi
- Élxi

Remaining Main Story Timeline Still in Summary:

Chapter 1 — Apprentice

Training, Palace introduction, classmates, basic spells, first controlled duels. The player also gains access to the Library, where he can learn more about spells, review what he's learned, and talk to other NPCs.

Chapter 2 — First Missions

The player leaves the Palace for actual assignments. Scouts and basic disturbances introduce the player to the Mágos Wars.

Chapter 3 — Escalation

Duelists begin appearing. Missions become less controlled.

Chapter 4 — Ancient Magic

Sisters appear. The player discovers that the enemy is using forms of magic that shouldn't be possible under the Fundamental Limits. This is where the game's rules start becoming important to the story. The player participates in the Trials and becomes independent, learning the remaining spells from the library.

Chapter 5 — The Breaking Point

The player becomes important enough that the Phylarchoi begin trusting them with serious missions. The conflict gets increasingly dangerous, and the player's teacher becomes directly involved.

Chapter 6 — Diaphthairo

The player witnesses the first successful casting of Diaphthairo on their teacher. This is the point where the conflict stops being "a dangerous magical war" and becomes something fundamentally worse. The player also becomes a Phylarch and gains access to the Restricted Section of the Library.

Chapter 7 — The Mother

The player eventually confronts the Mother and has to survive an opponent who can violate the rules of magic that the player has spent the entire game learning.

17.2 Side Quests

Help students and citizens with their requests.

Side quests provide rewards.

18. Performance & Accessibility

18.1 Performance Goals

Minimum Frame Rate: 72 FPS

The game should never fall below 72 FPS.

Preferred Frame Rate: 90 FPS

Loading Times: Under 10 seconds.

18.2 Accessibility Options

The game should support:

- Right-handed mode.
 - Left-handed mode.
 - Seated mode.
 - Standing mode.
 - Snap turning.
 - Smooth turning.
 - Locomotion comfort options.
 - Subtitles.
 - Adjustable gesture sensitivity for casting.
 - Adjustable gesture sensitivity for movement.
 - Configurable swimming method.
-

19. Development Priorities / Open Items

The following items are currently incomplete or intentionally lower priority.

Dark magic: Low priority; add after the other spells.

Story Development

Main story progression after the introductory lessons: TBD.

Swimming

Physical arm-swing method considered; Joystick/head-direction method planned.

Spell Progression

Spell progression should generally follow increasing difficulty, with the documented exceptions for Óthisi and Asfalís.

Further details are TBD.

Considered Additions

In the Athean world, Aquari will sometimes ride dolphins to traverse large distances of the city more quickly. A potential application of this is to give the player access to the stables in Chapter 3 of the main progression, allowing him to more quickly travel Athea.

20. Glossary

Athea—the underwater city where the game takes place.

Aquari—the fictional species resembling human form that populates Athea.

Mágos Wars—the age in history in which the game takes place

Adelphía—the rebellion; a magical group consisting of the female magicians capable of Ancient Magic.

Phylarch—a specially-trained magician employed by the Board of Magic whose goal is to find Ancient Magicians and end the rebellion.

Phylarchoi—a) plural of Phylarch b) the magical subgroup of the Board of Magic whose main goal is to end the Adelphía.

Bibliarch—the main librarian at the Palace Library.

Ancient Magic—a type of mysterious magic only capable by a few female Aquari that gives the caster strange unique powers

Tidal Code—A set of rules enforced by the Board of Magic used to keep things in order.

Board of Magic—A group of experienced magicians who lead the rest of the Magicians.

Trials—A set of tests for a young magician used to complete the student's training.

Crystal—A magical conduit by which a magician channels his magic.

Succession—a word used to describe the after-ness of something in timeline or the higher ranking (as in the King succeeds the Prince.)

Active Spell—the spell that takes place from upon trigger pressed to trigger released.